

Scholarships & Grants

Free money for school and training is everywhere — if you know where to look. Below are trusted, free national starting points. Tick the box once you've checked each one.

⚠ BEFORE YOU START

Real scholarships are always free to apply for. The #1 rule: never pay a fee to search for or “win” a scholarship. The free tools below list the same opportunities paid services charge for.

1 Free Scholarship Search Tools

Trusted, free databases of scholarships.

☐ CareerOneStop Scholarship Finder

A free, official Department of Labor database of 9,000+ scholarships and grants.

→ www.careeronestop.org/Toolkit/Training/find-scholarships.aspx

☐ Federal Student Aid — Scholarships

Government guidance on finding and winning scholarships.

→ studentaid.gov/understand-aid/types/scholarships

2 Don't Forget Grants

Grants are need-based free money — start with the FAFSA.

☐ File the FAFSA

Unlocks Pell and state grants. See the Financial Aid Basics guide.

→ studentaid.gov/h/apply-for-aid/fafsa

☐ Pell Grant

Up to ~\$7,395/year you never repay.

→ studentaid.gov/understand-aid/types/grants/pell

3 Look Close to Home

Local and niche scholarships have less competition.

☐ Local & Community Scholarships

Check your school counselor, library, employer, church, and local clubs — smaller scholarships are easier to win.

→ **Ask your school counselor or library**

☐ Scholarships for Your Situation

Many scholarships target specific careers, backgrounds, or communities. Search your field/background + “scholarship.”

→ **Search your situation + 'scholarship'**

4 Apply Smart

A little strategy wins more money.

☐ Reuse One Strong Essay

Write one solid essay you can adapt, and apply to many smaller scholarships — volume wins.

→ Apply to many smaller scholarships

⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

Never pay for a scholarship search or to “release” a scholarship you’ve “won” — those are scams. The CareerOneStop database is free and lists the same scholarships paid sites do.

★ A TIP THAT HELPS

Apply to lots of small, local scholarships rather than only the big famous ones — they have far less competition, and several \$500 awards add up fast.

NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

Need help where you live?

This guide covers national tools. For scholarships specific to your field, school, or community, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID
